> small balls, and in the evening…they make khichari, which consists of rice cooked with grain…in water with a little salt.

While Akbar remained at the Mughal stronghold of Burhanpur 20 kilometres away, Abu'l Fazl prepared to besiege Bahadur Shah at Asirgarh Fort. This fort was Bahadur Shah's 'chief stronghold', wrote the Jesuits, 'which on account of its site, and as possessing every other feature that could render a fortress strong, appeared to be impregnable, being placed on a high mountain five leagues in circuit and surrounded by three concentric lines of fortifications…. Besides water from a living well, there was within the fort sufficient wood, vegetables and other provisions to support for many years the 70,000 soldiers who defended it. It was fortified with 3,000 pieces of artillery, most of which were so large that the noise of their discharge was like terrific thunder.' Safe in the embrace of this forbidding fortress, Bahadur Shah girded himself for war.

In the early stages of the siege of Asirgarh, Akbar suffered a debilitating loss, away from the battlefield. Jiji Anaga, who had travelled with the army, as had the rest of the harem, 'died after much suffering' and Akbar was inconsolable. He shaved his head and his moustache in a sign of grief, the first time in his life he was recorded as doing so. Though he expressly forbade it, all his servants followed their Padshah, united in their grief for one of the grand old ladies of the harem who had followed every step of Akbar's turbulent life with selfless love. Even 'while old', agreed Abu'l Fazl, 'she had a youthful mind. She was very well-disposed, and gracious of heart.' Akbar carried her bier on his shoulders for part of the way to her temporary grave. Jiji Anaga would later be buried next to her husband in a jewel-like tomb called Ataka Khan's tomb near Nizamuddin Auliya's dargah, as Delhi became crowded with the ghosts of the matriarchs of the Mughal Empire. Even today Delhi sparkles with the memory of the singular destiny of Jiji Anaga's family. There is her daughter Mah Banu's tomb, known today as Abdur Rahim's tomb; there is Ataka Khan and Jiji Anaga's tomb, and there is her son Mirza Aziz Koka's Chausath Khamba, all within 1 kilometre of each other with at their spinning heart the holy presence of Nizamuddin Auliya's dargah.

Mirza Aziz Koka and Shaikh Farid joined Abu'l Fazl in the attack on Asirgarh Fort. Almost immediately, a number of officials from within the fort quietly defected. In May 1600, Bahadur Shah pretended to sue for peace by sending to the Mughal camp his mother and young son, along with